

Price cuts, up ahead

A fresh line of price cuts is expected from the stables of Intel. The prices of 533 MHz FSB Pentium 4 processors will be cut by to 30 per cent on 11 May, ahead of the introduction of 800 MHz FSB equivalents ten days later, the company has told its distributors.

The new pricing structure, according to the Web site, X-bit Labs, will see the 2.8 GHz P4 fall in price from \$ 375 to \$ 262—a fall of 30 per cent.

The 2.6 GHz falls to \$ 193 from \$ 241 and the 2.4 GHz from \$ 193 to \$ 163. The 3.06 GHz P4 will stay at \$ 401.

The move is aimed at knocking the prices of these chips down to less than the introductory price of 800 MHz parts. The new comers are expected on 21st May, the report claims, with the 2.8 GHz P4C coming in at \$ 278, the 2.6 GHz P4C at \$ 218 and the 2.4 GHz P4C at \$ 178.

The 'C' indicates 800 MHz bus support, the parts also support HyperThreading. All this paves the way for the arrival of the 3.2 GHz P4C at the end of the quarter for \$ 637, says X-bit Labs.

In addition, Intel will cut the prices of its Celeron range on 27 April. The parts affected are the 1.8 GHz to 2.4 GHz chips, falling by up to 23.9 per cent. The 1.7 GHz processor will remain at \$ 54.

Data squeeze

Plextor has announced a new CD-ReWritable drive that can squeeze 40 per cent more data into standard blank discs. The PlexWriter Premium can pack 980 MB of data into a 700 MB disc and 1.2 GB into an 880 MB disc, according to the CD gear maker. It does so using the GigaRec option in the bundled PlexTools Professional software, working with the drive's hardware.



The increased use of space is achieved by burning up to 40 per cent smaller pits into the surface of a blank disc, thus granting more real estate. Such a special nature of the pits might not allow a standard drive's laser to read the media properly. The Premium line will ship as a standard internal IDE drive and as

an external USB 2.0 unit. They will feature 52X read and write-once speeds, and a 32X speed for rewritable media.

For some time now, enthusiasts have been able to make use of between 10 percent and 20 per cent more data than the rated capacity of a disc by overburning, or writindata onto portions of a discs normally left untouched. However, such discs often cannot be read by normal CDROM drives.

Watch me

Nokia introduced a new kind of MMS device for the Americas market, the Nokia Observation Camera. The dual-band Camera is expected to be available during



the third quarter of 2003. After being mounted in a covered area and connected to a power source, the Nokia Observation Camera can be pointed at any area that needs to be monitored. It can be set to send images automatically to an MMS-enabled handset or an e-mail address at pre-determined intervals, when motion is detected, when a change in temperature is noted or when an SMS query is sent directly to the device. It can also report ambient temperature via SMS or open a voice channel for live audio monitoring.

The Big Blue Office suite

IBM is preparing a slimmer alternative to Microsoft's ubiquitous Office suite. It is planned as a set of applications that will run on corporate Web servers. The business productivity applications comprise of word-processing, spreadsheet and e-mail software. IBM said its applications are not intended to go head to head with the advanced features of Office but are aimed at those that do not require the advanced features that Microsoft's products offer. They hope that the low-cost associated with their office suite, will attract corporations.



According to company officials, there will always be 10 to 15 per cent of people who need the full mail, spreadsheet and document-writing capabilities, while the other 85 per cent do not wish to pay huge fees for features they don't need.

The applications, due in the second quarter of this year, are for companies that need to do simple e-mail, text-editing and spreadsheet work. The

applications will not be sold alone, IBM will bundle them with its WebSphere portal server software.

Developed in the company's Lotus division, the applications are part of IBM's NextGen strategy for revamping its Lotus products. The first product of the NextGen plan was a lightweight e-mail client called IBM Lotus Workplace Messaging, aimed at people who use e-mail on a limited basis. The forthcoming office applications will also have the Workplace label, according to IBM executives.

snapshot

57% of U.S. companies already support **wireless** networks and **another 22% will implement it within the next year.**

Source: Jupiter Research